

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

2 Corinthians

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Second Corinthians shows Paul as a pastor. He deeply wanted the Christians in Corinth to be close to him again. He believed that the good news (the gospel) is mainly a message of reconciliation, which means bringing broken relationships back together.

Some Christians criticized Paul and accused him of being a weak leader. Because of this, Paul had to defend himself. In this letter, he speaks openly to the Corinthian church in a way that is different from his other letters.

Paul faced many dangers, including threats to his life. But one of his hardest trials was being falsely accused by Christians whom he had helped lead to Christ. Paul's example shows how Christ loves his church. It gives encouragement and hope to Christian leaders and their churches.

Setting

The apostle Paul first came to Corinth during his second missionary journey (see Acts 18:1-20). Corinth was already an old city in Paul's day. By the 500s BC, it had become a large and important city. It was a center for trade, business, and city life.

Rome controlled Corinth after Julius Caesar rebuilt the city in 44 BC. After that, Corinth became known for its fine buildings, shops, theaters, and houses. Trade made the city wealthy. Workers in Corinth made bronze objects, pottery, and clay lamps. These clay lamps were well known across the ancient world (see 2 Corinthians 4:7). Farming also helped Corinth become wealthy (see 9:6-10; 1 Corinthians 3:6-9; 9:7, 10). Beginning in 27 BC, Achaia, the region of southern Greece, came under the control of the Roman senate. This happened because Corinth was important for trade and was in a useful location.

Writers from Paul's time tell us about religious life in Corinth. Many people there worshiped Aphrodite, the Greek goddess of life, beauty, and sexual desire. The Romans called her Venus. Strabo, an ancient Greek writer, said that Aphrodite had a large temple on a hill above the city. He also said the temple was connected with prostitution. Because of reports like this, many people have said that Corinth was known for serious sexual sin.

Today, scholars are more careful about this claim. Strabo may have spoken badly about Corinth because

Corinth and nearby Athens were political rivals. Still, we know that Paul was aware of serious moral problems in Corinth. We know Paul wrote Romans 1:18-32 while in Corinth (see Romans Book Introduction, "Date, Place, and Occasion of Writing"; compare Acts 20:2-3). His letters, especially 2 Corinthians, show that Paul knew about moral problems among the Christians there (see 2 Corinthians 6:14-17; 12:19-21).

Paul brought the message of Christ into this city. By God's grace, and through Paul's ministry, a group of believers was formed. This young church began to grow.

Paul thought of the Christians in Corinth as his children (6:13; 12:14; 1 Corinthians 4:15). They came from many parts of Corinthian society. Corinth was a city known for its interest in wisdom, public speaking, popular culture, trade, its two harbors, and its love of life.

In 2 Corinthians 11:23-28, Paul lists many trials he had faced. At the end of the list, he writes, "I face daily the pressure of my concern for all the churches." No church seems to have caused Paul more concern than the church in Corinth.

Summary

This letter responds to challenges against Paul's authority as an apostle, a person sent by Christ. It also responds to false teachers who had entered the church.

In the first half of 2 Corinthians (chapters 1-6), Paul explains Christian service. Suffering for Christ is a necessary part of this service (1:1-24). This suffering is hard to endure when other Christians hurt us (2:1-17).

The good news about Jesus brings life through the Holy Spirit and gives God's salvation. It replaces the old covenant, the earlier agreement God made with Israel. But it is also connected to that covenant (3:1-18). God's message shows its power through the weakness of God's servants (4:1-18). This message centers on the death of God's Son. Through his death, God brings us back into his favor (5:1-21). Christian life is marked by devotion to God. This devotion sets believers apart from the evil ways of the world (6:1-18).

In the second half of the letter (chapters 7-13), Paul explains why he wrote his letters to Corinth (see 7:1-16). He also teaches about giving and stewardship, which means using God's gifts in a faithful way. He does this while discussing the collection for the church in Jerusalem (8:1-9:15). Then Paul strongly defends his work as an apostle. Some people spoke against him

because they thought his weakness made him less important (chapters 10–13).

Author

Most scholars agree that Paul wrote 2 Corinthians. There is one main exception. Some scholars think 6:14–7:1 may not have been written by Paul. They suggest that another person may have added it later. They say this because the words in this passage are similar to words found in the Dead Sea Scrolls, a group of ancient Jewish writings.

It is more likely that Paul wrote this passage as a short side discussion. It may also have come from another letter Paul wrote to the Corinthian church and was placed here later.

In either case, Paul himself most likely wrote this material. He wrote it to address the moral and spiritual problems in the church at Corinth.

Date and Occasion of Writing

During his two- to three-year stay in Ephesus, from AD 53 to 56, Paul wrote 1 Corinthians. He sent it to the church in Corinth with Timothy (see 1 Corinthians 16:10–11; 1 Corinthians Book Introduction, “Date and Occasion of Writing”).

It seems that the Corinthians did not receive 1 Corinthians well. Some of them began to question Paul’s authority as an apostle. Paul had already expected this problem (1 Corinthians 4:18–21). But the challenge became louder and more forceful.

So Paul made a personal visit from Ephesus to Corinth (2 Corinthians 2:1). This visit seems to have failed. Paul’s opponents stood against him. A leading member of the church also insulted him in front of the congregation.

Paul returned to Ephesus in deep distress. Then he wrote a letter that gave strong correction (sometimes called the “severe letter”). He sent it to Corinth with Titus (2:3–13). That letter has been lost but it helped bring the Corinthians to repentance (7:8–10).

Meanwhile, Paul left Ephesus after severe trials (Acts 19:23–41; see also 1:8–11; 4:8–15; 6:4–10). He then traveled to Macedonia (Acts 20:1). In Macedonia, Paul met Titus, who had come from Corinth. Titus gave Paul a very encouraging report about the situation in the Corinthian church (2 Corinthians 7:5–7).

In response to this report, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians around AD 56. He sent the letter back to Corinth with Titus (8:6, 16–19). Paul later traveled to Corinth himself. He stayed there for three months (see Acts 20:1–3).

The Unity of 2 Corinthians as a Letter

Paul certainly wrote 2 Corinthians. However, some scholars ask whether the whole book was first written and sent as one letter.

Second Corinthians 6:14–7:1

In 1 Corinthians 5:9, Paul mentions an earlier letter that he had sent to Corinth. In that letter, he wrote about whether Christians should spend time with sexually immoral people. That earlier letter has been lost.

Some scholars think part of that earlier letter may be found in 2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1. This passage speaks about the same subject. This view may explain why 6:14–7:1 seems to interrupt the discussion. Without this section, the thought would move smoothly from 6:13 to 7:2. However, Paul often moved away from his main point for a short time when he wrote his letters. So 6:14–7:1 may simply be a short side discussion.

Second Corinthians 10:1–13:14

The last four chapters of 2 Corinthians are difficult to explain. Their tone is angry and sharp. Some scholars think these chapters may be part of Paul’s “severe letter” (see 7:8). But this is not likely. The Corinthians responded to Paul’s severe letter with repentance (7:9). It makes more sense to see chapters 10–13 as written later than chapters 1–9. Paul may have written them in response to a new problem. False teachers had come to Corinth (compare 11:4, 12–15).

The Corinthians warmly welcomed these teachers. The teachers soon reopened old hurts. These “super-apostles” suggested that Paul was not a true apostle nor even a Christian at all (see 10:7, 10; 11:5; 12:11).

When Paul saw the danger, he wrote a strong letter. He used irony, sharp criticism, and self-defense. At the center of chapters 10–13 is Paul’s “Fool’s Speech” (11:16–12:10). In this speech, Paul speaks as if he were boasting because he feels forced to do so (11:1, 16–17).

We do not know whether the words in chapters 10–13 stopped these threats. We also do not know whether they defended Paul’s authority as an apostle again in Corinth.

After this letter, Paul visited Greece. Corinth was probably part of this trip (Acts 20:2). Later, he sailed to Jerusalem with the money that the churches had given, including the church in Corinth.

So Paul’s last letter to Corinth may have been the most effective one. The Corinthians may finally have accepted him again. About 40 years after Paul’s letters to Corinth, a letter called 1 Clement spoke warmly

about Paul's ministry. A church leader in Rome wrote this letter to the Corinthians.

Meaning and Message

Second Corinthians is a very personal letter. It helps people see Paul's inner life: his thoughts, feelings, and deep concerns. For this reason, many people have called it Paul's most personal letter.

The Work of an Apostle

The first half of the letter explains the responsibilities and privileges of an apostle (2 Corinthians 1:1–7:16). The message of the gospel is new (3:1–18). Those who proclaim it must show its truth by the way they live. The gospel also brings reconciliation, bringing broken relationships back together (5:1–21).

The Central Message of the Gospel

Chapter 5 contains one of the most complete accounts of Paul's main message (5:18–21). Paul had already told the Corinthians that he preached Christ crucified (1 Corinthians 1:18–2:2). Now he explains how this message applies to their situation.

Because of sin, people are not at peace with God. So God acted to meet human need. In Christ, God dealt with sin and separation from God. Christ became human and took our sin on himself at the cross.

Through Christ, God brings us back into a relationship of peace and acceptance with him. Paul urges people to be reconciled to God, which means to be brought back into a right relationship with him (2 Corinthians 5:20).

This restored relationship must continue through all of life. This means staying faithful to the gospel as Paul preached it. It also means staying away from moral evil, including the kinds of sin that troubled the city of Corinth.

The Call to Holy Living

his letter often calls Christians to live a holy life, a life set apart for God. Paul uses two main images. He describes the church as a temple and as a bride (6:14–7:1; 11:2).

Both images point to purity and devotion to God. The temple is the holy place where people worship God. In the same way, God's people should be set apart to worship and serve him.

The bride of Christ should be faithful to Christ, just as a wife should be faithful to her husband.

The Need for Generous Giving

Paul spends two long chapters on this topic (8:1–9:15). The Christians in Corinth were in conflict with each other. They needed to think about the needs of others, especially the poor Jewish believers in Jerusalem. The Lord Jesus Christ, who became human, is our greatest example of sacrificial giving (8:9).

At Corinth, the main issue was the gospel as shown in the way of the cross. Paul suffered and was weak as an apostle. To the believers in Corinth, this seemed to go against his authority. But the gospel centers on Christ's suffering for other people. Christians receive life because Christ suffered for them. This truth still matters for Christian leaders and for daily Christian life today.